I Love You

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/55413850.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora/Suffering

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Horde Adora (She-Ra), Horde Lord Adora (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - Adora Remains with the Horde (She-Ra), Catra Leaves the Horde (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), POV Catra (She-Ra), Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Angst, Hurt No Comfort, Tragedy, Why Did I Write This?, Darkest Timeline, I had to take a crying break while I wrote this, Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra)

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2024-04-23 Words: 1,738 Chapters: 1/1

I Love You

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/55413850.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora/Suffering

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Horde Adora (She-Ra), Horde Lord Adora (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - Adora Remains with the Horde (She-Ra), Catra Leaves the Horde (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra is in Love with Adora (She-Ra), POV Catra (She-Ra), Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Angst, Hurt No Comfort, Tragedy, Why Did I Write This?, Darkest Timeline, I had to take a crying break while I wrote this, Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra)

Language:
English

Stats:
Published: 2024-04-23 Words: 1,738 Chapters: 1/1

I Love You

by Catgirl_Soph

Summary

Lord Adora is victorious.

Hordak has been killed, Brightmoon conquered, Prime defeated, and even She-Ra subdued. There's now nothing left standing between Adora and mastery of the whole universe, nothing except her kitten and her humanity.

Everyone she's ever loved has used her, abused her, reduced her, but she won't let them in anymore. Lord Adora has a duty to honour, a destiny to fulfill, and she has to do so no matter the cost...

Notes

Inspired by my dark thoughts during Magicatra AUs when Adora has no-one and Catra's barbs are getting just a little too vicious.

“Hey Adora. Has my savior come to rub her victory in my face yet again? Very protective, truly, I’m swooning already."

She was taken aback slightly when Adora failed to respond, but only for a moment. If Adora was too tongue tied to offer her own retort than wonderful, Catra had the upper hand already!

“Are you giving me the silent treatment or did I just take your breath away?”

Adora offered no response, at least no verbal one. She just kept walking, painfully slowly, towards Catra’s cage. Her face was visible now, wrapped in a sad little smile that said so much and nothing at all. Part of Catra wanted to be scared, but another part was infuriated at feeling ignored. The latter emotion was easier, so she leaned into it.

“Awww, is little miss perfect not happy getting everything she wants? Did she expect me to fall to my knees and beg for forgiveness like a good little kitten? Scream and weep to be let back into this putrid hellscape you choose to serve?”

A few moments of silence passed before Adora finally reached the iron bars. She sat down and stared at Catra, but not in the familiar, piercing way Catra was used to. Her smile remained, but her eyes betrayed just how resigned it was. For 5, 10, 15 seconds, the air was at peace.

“What is this Adora? *What* do you want from me?

…

“Stop looking at me like that! You made your choices and I made mine.”

…

“Are you waiting for me to break, to console you like I used to, tell you you're the good person you’ve always been so desperate to be while you mow down villages and turn a blind eye to the suffering of the only person who ever loved you!?

For just a moment, Adora’s smile wavered, before returning more broken than ever.

“You never loved me Catra.”

Catra had never been a stranger to fear, but in that moment her blood ran colder than it ever had before.

“You used me, ever since we were kids. I was *so* stupid for so long, even when the answer was staring me right in the face. Shadow Weaver told you the only reason she let you live was

because I liked you, and so you pretended to be my friend. You used me for protection from her, tricked me into thinking you liked me even though I would have allowed you to use me without question if you were honest, and after opening that door it was all just so much easier for you wasn't it? I bet it was easy for you to use me for my rations when yours were confiscated, as simple as all the times you used me to vouch for you all the times you got into trouble, as natural as every time you used me as your punching bag because I was the only one who wouldn’t punch back.”

“Adora no, it wasn’t like that!”

Adora laughed. It wasn’t like her old laughs, that carefree, friendly giggle she let out as a child when they played and pulled pranks together. No, this new laugh was different, deeper in tone, hanging in the air like a virus. As a child when Adora laughed this hard she moved erratically, throwing her head back, putting her hand over her mouth, looking at Catra with her big, friendly eyes. Now Adora was still looking at her, but it was off. Her smile was a bit too big, her body was far too rigid, and her eyes glared at Catra with some uncanny mix of love, malice, nostalgia and certainty. She looked less ashamed of enjoying herself then she once did, less ashamed and yet, somehow, more stilted. It was so different, so eerie, and yet Catra knew it was genuine from the way it slowly fizzled out, leveling off into deep sighs and sharp fits of giggling before finally settling into a gaze of revenant admiration.

“By Gods your good Catra, you know me so well. Even after everything you still make me so happy; I’m gonna miss you so fucking much.”

“Adora… what are you going to do to me?”

The slow but steady river of tears across Adora’s face didn’t slow down her speech even a second.

“I admire you Catra, I really do. I’ve always had a destiny to fulfill, a greater purpose so totalizing it left almost nothing for me, but you never had to worry about that. You still have your place in the Universe, you still trained me for power more thoroughly then anyone else could, but you did that just by being you. You got to be free.”

“Adora, no, you don’t have to do this! You won dammit, you don’t have to do *anything* !”

Catra could hear the desperation, the horror, the *weakness* in her voice, but couldn’t muster the effort to care.

“Adora, we can still be together! I’m sorry for everything I’ve done, I didn’t mean to hurt you! I LOVE YOU, whether you believe me or not I still do! I didn’t mean to use you, *I love you Adora* , and I’m so fucking sorry for everything. Whatever happened in the past, it's over now, *you won* , I’m in a cage! You don’t have to be strong anymore. I’ll do whatever you want, I surrender Adora, you win! You can have the world, you can have the universe, and you can have me in whatever way you want me, just please don’t let us end like this.”

She was panicking now and she knew it.

She'd failed as a friend,

As a soldier,

As a lover,

As a person,

And now, from the look in Adora's eyes,

She knew she'd failed to reach her.

She was going to die,

Adora was going to kill her,

Adora was going to kill herself in every way that mattered,

Adora, please no.

Her panicking was cut off when she felt Adora's hand cup her chin, her lips graze her own, and her tongue throwing itself at her as if she were a meal, as if Adora could stay with her forever by consuming her. She felt the passion, the love, and the hopelessness hit her all at once. Such a crushing sense of finality, wrapped in a complete disregard for the terror of intimacy that'd been drilled so far deep in both their heads. It was by far the best and worst kiss Catra had ever felt, and she never wanted it to end.

In the end Adora didn't pull so much as float out of the kiss, her thumb taking to petting Catra's cheek as her beautiful eyes returned to the softness Catra had come to miss so much.

"The truth is that you own me, Catra. You own my heart, my past, even my soul. I know now that I should be mad at you, that I should hate you really, but I don't. Even when I can finally see you for who you really are, a part of me just screams to allow you to use me again, to serve and protect you and feel your soft, fluffy hand caressing me as you tell me you care. I love you Catra, I always have, and I always will."

"Adora no! You own you, you don't have to do this."

Adora's smile rose, which somehow made her look even sadder, but her eyes remained just as soft as ever.

“I want you to know that I followed your advice, that I’ve been thinking about our lives together and, I think I finally learned how to listen. The Fright Zone never gave you the respect you deserved, never recognized your talents or celebrated you like I was. I was blind to how much that hurt you when I could have done something about it, just one of the many things I was oblivious about I guess. I can’t go back in time and fix that, nor can I go back and save us from Shadow Weaver’s abuse or the princesses mind games, but I can promise you this.

I’ll build statues of you, big and small, imposing and personal. I’ll build statues of our playfighting, our little games and our banter on the Fright Zone rooftop. I’ll build statues commemorating your genius, your tactics and strategy and the way you thought circles around me so many times. Most of all though I’ll build statues celebrating your ambition, your survival, how little life gave you and how much you got from it in turn. I can’t fix the past, but I *will* make sure no one ever disrespects you again. You kept me alive, occasionally even happy, during the worst years of my life, and then you made me strong enough to fulfill my destiny against a whole universe of obstacles. I’ll never be able to pay you back for that Catra, but I’ll do my best anyway.``

They were both crying now, but whereas Adora allowed her tears to stream down her cheeks, Catra practically coughed as her body rebelled against itself. The war was over, Shadow Weaver was gone, she was alone with Adora now, there really was no need to be strong anymore, but try as she might she just couldn't bring herself to break with 23 years of habit.

“I’m sorry Adora”

“I’m sorry too Catra.”

Minutes passed as they cried in each other’s arms, mourning every second of the future together they’d thrown away. Catra thought for a moment about escaping, making a run for it now that Adora had opened her cage’s door, but her feet stayed planted. The Fright Zone was too big and too well guarded for her to make it out and more importantly there just wasn’t any point. She’d rather spend this last little bit of her life with the woman she loved then running away from what she knew she deserved. An eternity later, Adora unsheathed her sword and gave Catra a bare sliver of hope, a morsel she’d treasure for the rest of her life.

“Catra, if there’s an afterlife, I’d love nothing more than to spend it with you one day, if you’ll have me.”

Catra took a while to respond, not to consider but to process. Finally she grabbed Adora’s free hand and squeezed it as tightly as she could.

“Yeah. I’d like that.”

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!